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Question 1:

The last lines of novels often leave the reader pondering the meaning of the entire story.

Take one last line from a novel and consider what it means by connecting it to other important quotes/support for your argument, considering what it means for characterization(s), and what it means for the meaning of the novel as a whole.

Last Lines of The Great Gatsby:

Gatsby believed in the green light, the orgastic future that year by year recedes before us. It eluded us then, but that's no matter tomorrow we will run faster, stretch out our arms farther... and one fine morning. So we beat on, boats against the current, borne back ceaselessly into the past.

Ending of *The Great Gatsby*: The Melancholic Disillusionment of the American Dream

When a reader finally finishes *The Great Gatsby*, he must exclaim heartfully, that F. Scott Fitzgerald is not only an outstanding writer, but also an incisive social philosopher, who integrates his interpretation of the highly ethereal American dream into the symbolism behind the green light and the boat. Specifically, from my perspective, the ending of *The Great Gatsby* is an abstraction and metaphor that reveals the cruel yet inevitable disillusionment of the American dream under the bubble of capitalism and the immobilization of social classes during the 1920s. To summarize, this ending is not only an epitaph for Gatsby, but also an indictment of the hypocritical American dream.

The ending is written from Nick's point of view, represented in the form of his memory. As the last chapter opens with Nick's narration, "After two years I remember the rest of that day, and that night and the next day..." (p. 89), Fitzgerald begins foreshadowing the ultimate disillusionment of Gatsby's fantasy by making readers gradually sense the suffocating and melancholic atmosphere at the murder scene, where "an endless drill of police and photographers and newspaper men" (p. 89) implies the ephemeral glory before Gatsby's tragic death. As the story continues, readers could understand more clearly how helpless and desperate Nick, the last person who stands "on Gatsby's side, and alone" (p. 90), is, because "no one else was interested... with that intense personal interest to which every one has some vague right at the end" (p. 90) — by the poignant contrast between Gatsby's hilarious party and desolate funeral, Fitzgerald successfully materializes Nick's strong nihilism and emptiness after the sudden end of Gatsby's dream, which "must have seemed so close that he could hardly fail to grasp it" (p. 99), but eventually proves to be as distant as the green light.

In fact, the green light represents a kind of symbolism, or in other words, an object or entity with more significant meaning beyond itself. In my opinion, it is a mixture of hope and despair, dream and reality. At the beginning of the story, the green light embodies the desire of Gatsby to reunite with Daisy. Because day after day, Gatsby “stretched out his arms toward the dark water in a curious way” (p. 12) in direction of that green light, trying to reach the location “minute and far away, that might have been the end of a dock” (p. 12) where Daisy lives, just for regaining his long-lost true love. As the story unfolds, when Gatsby and Daisy re-encounter, Gatsby’s dream briefly comes into reality. Couldn’t restrain his excitement, Gatsby confesses to Daisy that he is thinking of her all the time by saying, “you always have a green light that burns all night at the end of your dock” (p. 49). At this point, that mysterious green light seems no longer an elusive shadow, but a concrete object, and this is the only time that the green light symbolizes reality. However, after Daisy’s betrayal and Gatsby’s death, at the end of the novel, the green light once again represents the illusory “orgastic future that year by year recedes before us” (p. 99), which keeps constantly being farther and farther away, without any possibility of becoming reachable.

Besides the green light, the boat also acts as a metaphor that connects to the larger motif, an element, concept, or idea throughout *The Great Gatsby*. Compared to the metaphor of the green light which only indicates the wishful illusion of Gatsby alone, the boat is more generic and reveals the predicament of the entire human society. Because every person in this world must move forward through obstacles by their own strengths, just like steering the boat in the wind and rain — same as the ups and downs of the boat, the twists and turns are the essences of life. After all, life is anything but a smooth journey, just as Nick says, “I was within and without, simultaneously enchanted and repelled by the inexhaustible variety of life” (p. 19). Throughout

the novel, from a poor boy whose parents are all “shiftless and unsuccessful farm people” (p. 52), to the “new money” millionaire, Gatsby’s life resembles a boat which starts from some anonymous stream but finally sails into the boundless ocean. However, like an uncontrollable vortex, the limitation of his family background and social class eventually reprieves Gatsby’s chance to realize his great American dream; instead, it mercilessly swallows all his hope and desire, and kills Gatsby with the weapon of the evil side of human nature.

In conclusion, by the metaphor of the green light, the ending of *The Great Gatsby* not only symbolizes the disillusionment of Gatsby’s seemingly near yet untouchable American dream, but also enhances the tragic characterization of Gatsby. Further, by the symbolism of the boat, the ending of *The Great Gatsby* encourages readers to think about the larger motif of life, the ceaseless voyage that people must struggle to paddle upstream in order to avoid the fate of becoming the outcasts of their time and society.

References

- [1] Fitzgerald, F. Scott. *The Great Gatsby*. Web. <https://www.wsfcs.k12.nc.us/cms/lib/NC01001395/Centricity/Domain/7935/Gatsby_PDF_FullText.pdf>. Accessed 6 March 2020.